



Bethesda more than made up for it with the Shivering Isles expansion, and later the Knights of the Nine questline.

Bethesda really likes starting us off as prisoners, well we guess it's a staple now, so we'll just have to deal with it. However, in Oblivion, it's not us but Martin Septim, the successor to the throne who takes the spotlight. We simply help him achieve his destiny. Your character truly shines during the side quests, which could make Oblivion feel like a completely different game at times. They sure did put a lot of work into them side quests. Not that we're complaining, we love the side quests!

The Elder Scrolls V **SKYRIM**

FUS ROH DAH! Everybody recognises that shout. If you don't then it's probably because you took an arrow to the knee-head, to the head. Phew, that was a close call. The fifth and latest addition to the Elder Scroll series, Skyrim, was launched on the 11th of November, 2011. That's 11.11.11, a memorable release date for a memorable game, nice. Now in terms of scale, Skyrim's map wasn't all that big, even smaller than Oblivion for that matter, but it was littered with mountains and the geography was much more rugged in comparison to previous titles. Remember

that thing we said about Bethesda taking fan criticism seriously? A lot of the changes made to Skyrim were actually incorporated from fan-made mods used in Oblivion, and even what they learnt from criticism on Fallout 3. Some say that Bethesda intentionally designed the game with gaps so that modders could fill them up themselves, it does sound kind of lazy, but it's ingenious too. You take it and turn it into what you want, which is exactly what ended up happening.

Skyrim also removed the ability to craft your own spells, which makes sense because while there were indeed some innovative spells that came out of it, it kind of broke the game with some of the more overpowered ones. The crafting system was still open to abuse though, allowing players to get the best gear in the



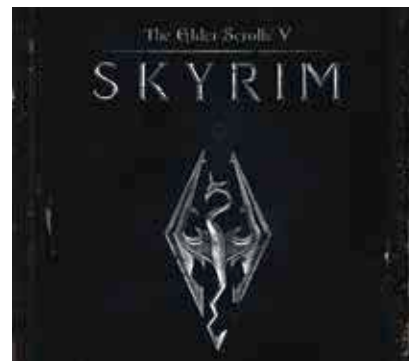
game at really low levels. Bethesda further improved the A.I., the combat, and of course, Dragon Shouts were added to the game. They did away with the older format of picking important skills beforehand, each race had different starting stats and abilities, but the player ultimately decided what skills would be leveled, without needing to actually choose them beforehand like in previous titles, but actually perform them in the game world to gain experience. They also added a perk tree – one of the things they picked up from Fallout – which netted you extra bonuses on leveling a skill up to a certain level. Each skill has its own perks.

Skyrim was also littered with Guardian Stones, ok not littered but there's

13 of them to be found, each of which gives some kind of bonus or a daily one-time use power or ability. These are useful when it comes to leveling up, and also kind of divided the character skills along the lines of the more traditional Warrior, Mage, Thief trope.

Skyrim had two major DLC expansions in the form of Dawnguard and Dragonborn, both of which added new areas to explore and new features into the game, including a more intricate "vampire" experience and the ability to fly a dragon.

Skyrim is often considered one of the best RPGs of all time, and even today, almost 5 years since its release, it's still played and has a very much active modding community who are still creating more and more content for the game. It's true what they say, you can't actually complete Skyrim.



Skyrim had you back in the shoes of the main character, the chosen one, the Dragonborn with powers gifted by the Gods and a destiny to fulfill. You still start off as a prisoner though, as usual. Unlike in Oblivion, more emphasis was on the main quest line. You have to take on the World Eater, Alduin, a Dragon trapped in time who has now returned to end the world. Sounds fun.

Conclusion

We can't possibly mention everything there is to the Elder Scrolls franchise in one article, there's simply too much to cover. There's boatloads of lore, interesting characters, countless side quests, there's just too much. But don't let that intimidate you, believe us, you want to dive headfirst for one of the best RPG experiences you will ever have. *